December, during a dinner at the Chilean embassy on Yunosti Street, Erich Honecker supposedly suffered a mild stroke. From then on, he was given sanctuary by Ambassador Clodomiro Almeyda, who himself had found refuge in the GDR during the Pinochet years. Though the Chilean government said it had refused a request for political asylum – the Honeckers remained inside the embassy as 'personal guests' of the ambassador, an action which threw up a whole series of new dilemmas. The embassy's Chargé d'Affaires, José Miguel Cruz, had clear memories of the Honeckers being installed in the best room, a kind of suite with a bathroom, where they listened to Deutsche Welle and received copies of the best West German newspapers daily. The decision to award this shelter was preceded by weeks of intense debate within the Chilean administration.33

An early offer of sanctuary from North Korea slipped away because of Russian objections (a special plane from Pyongyang, equipped with medical staff and an oxygen machine sat waiting at Moscow's Sheremetyevo airport).

In the wider world, as all this was happening, Mikhail Gorbachev agreed to the dissolution of the Soviet Union on 25 December 1991 and ceded all the powers still vested in it to Boris Yeltsin. Almost immediately, Russian authorities – against the wishes of the now powerless Gorbachev – again demanded that Honecker leave the country or else face deportation.

Over in Chile, while President Aylwin and a dozen senior Cabinet officials favoured giving sanctuary to Honecker, Bonn – which was perhaps its closest ally in the industrialised world – dangled the prospect of economic consequences. 'It affected the relationship between the president and the cabinet, in whose ranks many of its members had been exiled in the GDR,' recalled James Holger, a high-ranking official from the Chilean Foreign Ministry.

Having got wind of Honecker's predicament, Khalid Bakdash, leader of the Syrian Communist Party, offered the former General Secretary sanctuary in Damascus. The proposal was made in mid-January, when a party envoy pretending to apply for a visa, entered the Chilean Embassy to convey the invitation. According to Nidal Al-Shab newspaper, Honecker replied that